fended Shaminda Eranga to Herath at leg gully. Sri Lanka had won with a ball to spare.

I felt so badly for Jimmy, who, despite being named man of the series, was in tears during the post-match ceremonies. England's greatest bowler could not forgive himself for falling just short when his most singular achievement as a batsman was within reach. We might have been an odd couple when thrown together a decade earlier, but we have many things in common, including owing our promotion to the misfortune of others.

That tends to be the way of things in international cricket. I was first called up by England in 2005, when I was with the Academy squad at Loughborough, ironically training against reverse swing, a Pakistani speciality. I was indoors on the bowling machine before bowlers were introduced, to mind-blowing effect.

They used a ball with one pristine side and the other roughed up. It was doing all sorts, nigh on impossible to play. When I was pulled out and told to get to Multan because Michael Vaughan had injured his knee in the final warm-up match before the first Test, I momentarily panicked. I pleaded to be fed a diet of underarm deliveries, just so that I could get the feel of bat on ball again.

It was a surreal few days. It was the first time I'd heard my name on Radio 1, which was pretty cool for a twenty-one-year-old. I drove to Reading University to see Alice before submitting myself to the tender mercies of Pakistan Airways. Within twenty minutes of reporting to the team hotel I was invited into the Harmison Arms.

Steve would suffer severe homesickness but here, in a hotel room that acted as the centre of our universe, he was in his element. He ensured I didn't have time to remain awestruck at being alongside the Ashes heroes I had so recently watched on TV. I was quickly playing darts for the first time in my life and eating the sweets and snacks he had taken instead of his cricket gear. He basically travelled with his bat and his boots.

It was a very different experience, even before the horrors of the attack on the Sri Lankan team minibus sent the Pakistan team into enforced exile. On other tours, players splinter, visiting friends or restaurants. Here, we were all in it together, watching a lot of TV in team rooms. Culturally, we missed out, but to be honest visiting tourist sites loses its allure when you've had a four-hour practice session in 35-degree heat.